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Part 8 — Wiring your iPhone into your Linux machines

The payoff of this part: move files between your iPhone and your Linux laptop in one tap, share a clipboard and see your phone’s battery on the desktop, do the same to your Pi from anywhere over Tailscale, and know the one wired fallback (USB) for when Wi-Fi isn’t an option — without installing a pile of tools you’ll never use.

You’ve built a homelab your iPhone can reach. This part closes the loop in the *other* direction: getting your phone and your Linux machines to talk to each other for the everyday stuff — “send me that PDF,” “paste this URL onto my desktop,” “pull these photos off my phone.” On a Mac you’d reach for AirDrop and Handoff; on Linux you assemble the same conveniences from two small apps, plus one wired option you’ll rarely need.

The important framing up front: **these are three different tools solving three different problems**. Don’t think “which one wins” — think “which job am I doing.”

The two Wi-Fi tools, and why you want both

Job	LocalSend	KDE Connect (on iPhone)
Send files phone → Linux		
Receive files Linux → phone		
Share clipboard		
Phone battery on desktop		
Media remote control		
Mirror phone notifications to desktop		on iPhone (Android-only)
SMS / run commands from desktop		on iPhone (Android-only)
Dead-simple, one-purpose app		

! The iPhone reality check (this is where most guides mislead you)

KDE Connect’s headline features — notification mirroring, replying to texts from your desktop, running commands on the phone — are **Android-only**. Apple’s sandbox forbids a third-party app from reading other apps’ notifications or sending SMS, so on iOS none of that works no matter what a generic comparison table says. What the **iOS** KDE Connect app (v0.5.x as of 2026) *does* deliver is real and useful: file transfer, **clipboard sync**, **battery status**, and media remote control. One more iOS quirk: Apple’s background limits mean the KDE Connect app must be **open or recently used** to stay reachable — it can’t sit dormant for days and still answer.

LocalSend — your AirDrop replacement

Think of LocalSend as a dedicated screwdriver: it does exactly one thing, extremely well. Open it, pick a nearby device, send the file. No pairing, no account, no integration — and it cheerfully moves a 5 GB video that you’d never want to push through a more “integrated” tool.

That’s its entire job, and it’s the right tool whenever the task is purely “get this file from here to there.”

KDE Connect — your phone companion

KDE Connect is the multitool. File transfer is just one of its features; the reason to install it is the *integration* — on iPhone specifically, that means a **shared clipboard** (copy 192.168.1.50 on your phone, paste it on your desktop) and **battery status** on your desktop panel. The notification/SMS superpowers are Android’s; on iOS you’re here for clipboard and file flow.

“If KDE Connect transfers files, why install LocalSend?”

You don’t *have* to — plenty of people run only KDE Connect. The reason many keep LocalSend around anyway is sheer simplicity: when you just want to fling a big file across the room, LocalSend is two taps with zero ceremony. It’s like keeping a dedicated screwdriver even though your multitool has one. Disk is cheap; install both and reach for whichever fits the moment.

Install them

On the iPhone

Both are free on the App Store: search **LocalSend** and **KDE Connect** (the KDE Connect one is published by KDE e.V.). Install both.

On your Linux laptop

LocalSend — easiest via Flatpak (works the same on Arch and Ubuntu):

```
flatpak install flathub org.localsend.localsend_app
```

(Or grab the AppImage from the project’s GitHub releases if you don’t use Flatpak.)

KDE Connect — from your distro’s repos:

```
# Arch
sudo pacman -S kdeconnect

# Ubuntu/Debian
sudo apt install kdeconnect
```

i Running KDE Connect on Hyprland (no Plasma, no GNOME)

KDE Connect does **not** require the full KDE Plasma desktop — but it does need its background daemon running and a way to interact with it. On a bare window manager like Hyprland:

- The daemon `kdeconnectd` is started on demand over D-Bus; launching the GUI (`kdeconnect-app`) or running `kdeconnect-cli -l` brings it up.
- For an at-a-glance tray/battery indicator, add a **Waybar** “custom” module that calls `kdeconnect-cli`, or just keep `kdeconnect-app` a keybind away.
- Skip **GSConnect** — it’s a GNOME Shell extension and won’t help you on Hyprland. Plain `kdeconnect` is the right choice here.

Open the firewall

Both tools need their ports reachable on the LAN. If you run `ufw`:

```
sudo ufw allow 53317/udp      # LocalSend discovery + transfer
sudo ufw allow 53317/tcp
sudo ufw allow 1714:1764/udp  # KDE Connect
sudo ufw allow 1714:1764/tcp
```

If a transfer “sees” the device but hangs at 0%, a closed firewall port is the first thing to check.

Pair

- **LocalSend**: no pairing — open it on both devices, on the same Wi-Fi, and they appear in each other’s list. Send.
- **KDE Connect**: open the app on both, tap the laptop in the phone’s device list, and **accept the pairing request** on the desktop (`kdeconnect-app` or the CLI will prompt). Pairing is a one-time trust handshake.

Making it work *anywhere* — over Tailscale

Here's the homelab tie-in. Out of the box, both tools find devices using **LAN multi-cast/broadcast discovery** — great at home, useless the moment your phone is on cellular, because broadcast packets don't traverse a VPN. But your tailnet gives every device a stable 100.x.y.z address, and both apps let you **add a device by IP manually**, which sidesteps discovery entirely:

- **LocalSend:** Settings → **add a favorite / manual device** → enter the target's Tailscale IP (e.g. your laptop at 100.x.y.z) with port 53317. Now you can send to your laptop from the airport.
- **KDE Connect:** the iOS app has an “**Add device by IP**” / refresh option — enter the laptop's Tailscale IP. Pair once, and clipboard + file transfer work across the tailnet.

💡 Why this is the natural payoff of everything before it

This is the same trick that powered the whole series: discovery and “same network” assumptions break the instant you leave home, and Tailscale's stable addresses are the fix. Just as you reached Audiobookshelf and `https://home.home` by tailnet IP, you reach your *laptop* by tailnet IP here. The phone Linux conveniences stop being a home-only luxury.

Phone the headless Pi

A caveat worth stating plainly: LocalSend and KDE Connect are **desktop** tools. Your Pi from Parts 1–5 runs a **headless** server OS (Ubuntu Server 26.04 LTS) — no graphical desktop — so neither app is the natural fit there. For moving a file between your phone and the Pi, you already have better, GUI-free paths:

- **Drop it into a service you already run.** Files you want *on* the Pi (more audiobooks, say) can go straight into `~/Audiobooks` — `scp` them over the tailnet:

```
# from your laptop, over Tailscale, no LAN required
scp ~/Downloads/lesson.mp3 you@homelab:~/Audiobooks/
```

- **From the phone directly**, an iOS file-manager app that speaks SSH/SFTP (several exist) can connect to `homelab` over Tailscale and drop files onto the Pi without any desktop app in between.

In short: **laptop phone** is LocalSend/KDE Connect territory; **phone/laptop the headless Pi** stays SSH/`scp` territory, which you already have for free over Tailscale.

The wired fallback — USB access with libimobiledevice

Everything above is Wi-Fi. USB is a **completely separate technology stack**, and — honestly — most people rarely need it. Install it the day you actually hit one of these, not before:

- No Wi-Fi available and you need photos off the phone *now*.

- You're moving 100 GB of video and want the fastest possible transfer.
- The phone's networking is broken and you need emergency access.

When that day comes:

```
# Arch
sudo pacman -S libimobiledevice ifuse usbmuxd

# Ubuntu/Debian
sudo apt install libimobiledevice6 libimobiledevice-utils ifuse usbmuxd
```

Then plug in, trust the computer on the phone, and mount:

```
idevicepair pair                # tap "Trust" on the iPhone when prompted
mkdir -p ~/iphone
ifuse ~/iphone                  # mounts the phone's media (camera roll)
# ... copy your files ...
fusermount -u ~/iphone          # unmount when done
```

i What USB actually gives you (and what it doesn't)

`usbmuxd` is the daemon that talks to the phone over the USB cable; `libimobiledevice` is the library implementing Apple's protocols; `ifuse` mounts the result as a folder. Because of iOS's sandbox, `ifuse` exposes the **photos/ camera-roll area** (and, with extra flags, individual apps' document folders) — *not* the whole iOS filesystem. So USB is excellent for bulk photo/video offload, but it isn't a "browse my entire iPhone like a USB stick" experience. No jailbreak, no full filesystem — that's an Apple limitation, not a missing package.

If I were setting up your machine

Given your stack — iPhone, Hyprland, Arch/Ubuntu, plus the Pi homelab — start with exactly two things:

1. **LocalSend** (the AirDrop replacement)
2. **KDE Connect** (clipboard + battery + files)

...and nothing else. Add the Tailscale manual-IP pairing once you want these to work away from home. Then, *if* six months from now you find yourself saying "I wish I could pull my whole camera roll off over a cable," install `libimobiledevice` + `ifuse` — and at that point you'll understand exactly why you need them, instead of carrying tools you never touch.

For most people in 2026, Wi-Fi transfer (LocalSend / KDE Connect, extended over Tailscale) handles the overwhelming majority of phone Linux moments. USB is a backup and a power-user tool, not a daily requirement.

Recap — and the series, complete

- **LocalSend** = AirDrop replacement: dead-simple file send, install on both the iPhone and the laptop.
- **KDE Connect** = phone companion: clipboard sync and battery on iOS (the notification/SMS features are Android-only — don't expect them on iPhone).
- **Tailscale extends both off-LAN**: add devices by their 100.x.y.z IP so transfer and clipboard work from anywhere, exactly as the rest of your homelab does.
- **The headless Pi** stays on SSH/scp over Tailscale — the right tool for a machine with no desktop.
- **USB (libimobiledevice + ifuse)** is the wired fallback for bulk photo offload or no-Wi-Fi emergencies — install it only when you actually need it.

That completes *Beginner Homelab on a Raspberry Pi*. You started by building a foundation — a hardened, always-on Pi on a private Tailscale network — and then gave it job after job: streaming your media, blocking ads on every device, clean `http://*.home` URLs behind a reverse proxy, a single `https://home.home` control panel, a deliberate answer for VPN privacy on the road, and now two-way file sharing with your phone. Every piece runs on hardware you own, over one private network, with nothing exposed to the public internet.